SUBLIMINAL ADVERTISING

Advertisers use classical conditioning to associate a product with a stimulus that elicits the desired responses—belief in the product, positive emotions about the product, intent to buy the product—in the consumer. While shopping, a consumer sees the advertised can of soda, associates it with positive feelings, and therefore is more likely to purchase this brand of soda.

Stimuli that are subliminal are below the threshold of conscious perception. Consumers are not normally aware of subliminal stimuli unless they consciously look for them. For example, an image on a product package may contain the shape of sexual organs. There is some weak evidence that subliminal messages in advertising may positively affect the emotional quality of consumer attitudes toward a product. However, there is no evidence that subliminal messages affect consumer behavior toward a product.

THINKING VS FEELING

According to the University of Southern California (USC)'s Master of Science in Applied Psychology, advertising campaigns that perform well are almost twice as likely to employ emotional content (31 percent) as rational content (16 percent). An emotional response is more effective in inducing a person to complete a transaction, such as a purchase, than the content itself. One of the most powerful of these responses is when an advertisement comes off as "likeable." USC suggests audiences have two type of emotive, or emotional, responses: empathetic or creative. An empathetic response is when a person empathizes with a brand after being exposed to an advertisement. A creative response prompts the audience to feel that the product is imaginative and "cutting-edge." To achieve and maintain engagement, advertisers will try to have an audience feel joy or surprise immediately and to experience emotional ups and downs in the course of its advertisement.